

2. The Compromise Between Ethnic Minority Rulers and Han Landlords

Now, imagine such a scenario: ethnic minority rulers drive deep into the Central Plains (*Zhongyuan* / 中原). According to the needs of their social development, they would inevitably have to confiscate the land of the Han people and enfeoff it to their own tribesmen to establish feudal relations of subordination, thereby building a **feudal system** that matches their productive forces.

However, this would inevitably bring about two massive difficulties. The first difficulty is how to confiscate land from countless Han landlords across the vastly expansive region of Northern China. Depriving Han landlords of all their *means of production* (生产资料) is actually tantamount to taking their lives. Foreseeably, doing so would inevitably cause the barbarian rulers to face staggering resistance throughout the entirety of Northern China. The barbarian armies would have to confront the hostility of a population numbering in the tens of millions across a colossal territory of nearly two million square kilometers. The force of this resistance would be vastly greater than what William encountered in merely one England.

The second disadvantageous factor facing the barbarian rulers in Northern China was that, south of Northern China, there existed the Southern Dynasties (南朝) regimes—established and dominated by the northern Han aristocratic clans (*Shizu* / 士族) who had migrated south since the Eastern Jin Dynasty (东晋). Because of its cultural and bloodline purity, this regime always positioned itself as the orthodox legitimacy (正统) and continuously attempted to exert influence over the Han people in the north.

The prolonged tug-of-war in the Jianghuai region (江淮之间) made it impossible for the North and South to determine a victor in the short term. Furthermore, beyond the southernmost parts of Southern China lay nothing but the ocean and, at the time, impenetrable jungles. This allowed the southern regimes to relatively concentrate their forces to deal with the northern threat.

This point significantly distinguishes the situation from that of Europe. After the division of the Roman Empire, although the Eastern Roman Empire also claimed Roman orthodox legitimacy, and monarchs like Justinian I (查士丁尼一世) still took the reconquest of the Western Empire as their duty, it is undeniable that Eastern Rome's energy was constantly pinned down by formidable enemies in the east—initially the Second Persian Empire, and subsequently the rising Arabs and Turks. The geopolitical situation facing Eastern Rome made it impossible for it to cast its gaze westward for long. Consequently, shortly after the end of Justinian's reconquest, the Lombards (伦巴第人) easily invaded Italy.

The situation in India shared a certain similarity with China. By the second millennium CE, although Turkic Muslims and Mongol Muslims could relatively easily rule Northern India, the Hindu regimes nestled among the plateaus and towering mountains of Southern India could practically never be completely conquered. This political pressure perhaps also impacted the **feudalization** (封建化) of Islamic regimes in India, somewhat making it easier for Hinduism to regain dominance over most of the South Asian subcontinent after the British India (英属印度) period.

Therefore, we can see that even for the ethnic minority rulers of Northern China from the 4th to the 6th centuries, eradicating all resistance in Northern China through military force to establish a feudal regime was not entirely impossible; however, it would inevitably face numerous challenges

and highly likely could not be accomplished within a single generation. The risks involved in such an endeavor would be vastly greater.

Under these circumstances, let us hypothesize that the Han landlords—namely, the Han ruling class—offered a proposal of compromise. It demanded that the militarily superior ethnic minorities abandon the confiscation of land from the Han ruling class (the landlords) and refrain from establishing a feudal ruling order dominated by themselves. Instead, they would undergo *bureaucratization* (官僚化) according to the pre-existing bureaucratic political traditions of the Chinese Empire. In other words, the Khans and tribal chieftains would no longer transform into kings, grand dukes, marquises, and counts under a **feudal system**, but would instead become the emperors and *the myriad officials of the state apparatus* (公卿百官) of traditional China.

In this way, in the short term, both sides saw immense benefits. For the Han landlords (primarily the great aristocratic clans / 大士族), they retained their land and continued to exert political influence as members of the ruling class. For the ethnic minority rulers, the political situation in Northern China could swiftly stabilize; they no longer needed to risk their lives on battlefields where swords have no eyes. Instead, they could live the lifestyle of Southern Dynasties aristocrats while still wielding massive power.

For the supreme ruler of the ethnic minority himself, there was one additional supreme benefit: the monarch within China's traditional bureaucratic system possessed considerable sacredness and far more absolute power—something absolutely incomparable to a king or emperor under a **feudal system**, where the latter is merely the highest-ranking among **feudal lords**. Simultaneously, formally adopting China's bureaucratic system helped dress up their regime to look more like an orthodox Chinese regime (正统的中国政权). Once this was combined with the fact that they had already conquered the ancient capitals of Northern China—where the Han people originated and grew powerful—the minority emperors gained even more confidence in proclaiming their status as the orthodox rulers of China, convinced that they held the advantage even when facing the Han regimes in the south.

The seventh emperor of the Northern Wei (北魏), Tuoba Hong (拓跋宏), posthumously known as Emperor Xiaowen (孝文帝)—who has been infinitely elevated in Chinese official historiography—was a resolute supporter and executor of this compromise. Although this compromise evidently existed before Emperor Xiaowen began his rule—for example, Cui Hao (崔浩), an illustrious minister hailing from the Qinghe Cui clan (清河崔氏), achieved an extremely high political status during the reign of Emperor Taiwu (太武帝). But until that time, the Xianbei (鲜卑) rulers remained in a state of hesitation regarding whether a complete compromise with the Han landlord class was necessary; Cui Hao himself was executed after enduring humiliation in the "National History Case" (国史案).

Emperor Xiaowen resolved to end this hesitation. He decided to implement complete *bureaucratization* to fortify his supreme power as an Emperor of China. He went so far as to relocate the capital against massive opposition and even executed his own Crown Prince. Subsequently, following in the footsteps of Fu Jian (苻坚)—a previous ruler renowned as a minority emperor who respected Chinese traditions—he launched expeditions against the Southern Dynasties in an attempt to unify the entirety of China.

中文原文：

2，少数民族统治者与汉族地主的妥协

现在设想这样一种局面，少数民族统治者长驱直入进入了中原，那么按照其社会发展形势的需要来说，他必然要采取没收汉族人的土地分封给自己族人来确立封建隶属关系进而建立与生产力相匹配的封建制度。但是，这必然带来两个困难，第一个困难就是如何从地域如此广大的中国北方地区将土地从数不清的汉族地主手中没收过来。剥夺汉族地主全部的生产资料，实际上已经与取人性命无异了，可以预见的是，这样做势必会导致蛮族统治者在整个北中国都要面临惊人的反抗。蛮族的军队必须要在近两百万平方公里的庞大地域内面临上千万级别人口的敌意，这种抵抗的力量将远远大于威廉在区区一个英格兰所遭到的。第二个北中国的蛮族统治者面临的不利因素是，在北中国以南，还有一个自东晋以来北方南迁汉族士族为主导建立的南朝政权，这个政权因其文化和血统的纯粹性，总是以正统自居并且试图对北方的汉族人施加影响。江淮之间的长期拉锯，使得南北之间不可能在短时间内决出胜负，而中国南方的更南面除了大海就是当时难以涉足的丛林，这使得南方政权可以相对集中力量应对北方的威胁。这一点显著的与欧洲的情况区分开，在罗马东西分治之后，尽管东罗马也以罗马的正统自居，并且像查士丁尼一世这样的君主仍然以收复西帝国为己任，但是不可否认的是，东罗马的精力始终被东方的强敌所牵制着，一开始是波斯第二帝国，紧接着是崛起的阿拉伯人和突厥人。东罗马所面临的地缘形势使得他不可能长久地把目光放到西方，于是当查士丁尼的再征服结束之后，伦巴第人很快轻而易举地入侵了意大利。印度的情况和中国有一定相似性，到公元第二个千年，尽管突厥穆斯林和蒙古穆斯林能够比较容易地统治北印度，但是南印度的高原和崇山峻岭之间印度教政权几乎没办法被全数征服，这种政治上的压力，或许也影响到了伊斯兰政权在印度的封建化，多少使得经过英属印度时期印度教重新主导了南亚次大陆大部分地方变得更加容易。

所以我们可以看到，即使对于4到6世纪中国北方的少数民族统治者而言，通过武力翦除北中国的所有反抗进而建立一个封建政权虽并非不可能，但是必然需要面临诸多挑战，而且很可能不是一代人就能完成的，这其中所蕴含的风险就会大上许多。在这种情况下我们假设汉族地主，也就是汉族的统治阶级提供了这样一个妥协的议案，它要求在军事上占优势的少数民族放弃从汉族统治阶级（地主）手中剥夺土地，不去建立自己主导的封建统治秩序，而是按照中华帝国已有的官僚政治传统官僚化。也就是说，现在的汗王酋长们不再变成封建制度下的国王、大公、侯爵和伯爵，而是成为传统中国的皇帝和公卿百官。这样一来，短期内，双方都看到了极大的好处。对于汉族地主（主要是大的士族）来说，他们依然拥有着自己的土地，仍然作为统治阶级的一员在政治上发挥影响力；对于少数民族统治者而言，北中国的政治形势可以因此迅速稳定，自己不需要再冒着刀剑无眼的风险在战场上拼杀，而是过上南朝贵族式的生活并仍然拥有巨大权力。而对于少数民族的最高统治者本人来说，好处则还有一条，那就是中国传统官僚制中的君主具有相当的神圣性和更加绝对的权力，绝对不是一个封建制下的国王或者皇帝能比拟的，后者只是封建领主中级别最高的一个。与此同时，在形式上学习中国的官僚体制，有利于将自己的政权装扮得更像一个正统的中国政权，而一旦这一点与已经征服北方中国的故都，汉族正是在那里发源并且走向强大，相结合，少数民族皇帝就更有信心去宣示自己作为中国正统统治者的地位，确信自己面对南方的汉人政权也具有优势。北魏的第七个皇帝，也就是在中国官方史学中被无限拔高的孝文帝元弘，就是这种妥协的坚决支持者和执行者。尽管孝文帝开始统治之前，这种妥协显然就已经存在了，例如出身清河崔氏的一代名臣崔浩，他在太武帝一朝便取得了极高的政治地位。但是直到那个时候，鲜卑统治者对于是否有必要和汉族地主阶级进行彻底的妥协还是处于一种举棋不定的状态，崔浩本人也在“国史案”中遭受羞辱后被处决。孝文帝决心结束这种犹疑，他决定进行完全的官僚化来强化自己作为中国皇

帝至高无上的权力，甚至不惜顶着巨大的反对进行迁都，并杀掉了自己的太子，进而追随前一个以尊重中国传统的少数民族皇帝著称的统治者苻坚的脚步，对南朝发动讨伐以图统一整个中国。